

woman, unearthly in her radiance, a vision of light in the dark city. But then dawn arrives and the magical spell of nighttime is broken, just as Sylvia anoints Marcello's head with water from the fountain. The next day Sylvia leaves Rome, and Marcello must begin his search again.

The chaos of Marcello's night-wanderings is reflected in the movie's meandering, episodic story structure. His adventures take him all over the city, from a field in which two children claim to have seen a vision of the Virgin Mary—the archetypal elusive, idealized woman—to the domestic bliss of Steiner's house. Steiner (Alain Cuny) is Marcello's best friend, and the epitome of all that Marcello envies: Steiner is stable, happily married with two perfect children, and enjoys a balance of materialistic comfort and intellectual fulfilment. When Marcello visits Steiner's home, he ascends from the dark underworld of the streets, clubs, and basement bars, into a kind of heaven.

Illusion of happiness

But, just as Sylvia and the Virgin Mary turn out to be illusions, Steiner's domestic happiness is also a lie, as Marcello discovers when Steiner tells him, "Don't be

La Dolce Vita takes place over seven days, nights, and dawns. While day appears to offer Marcello hope, night leads him into depravity, and dawn brings rude epiphanies.

- Marcello follows Christ statue flying over Rome
- Climbs St. Peter's dome with Sylvia
- Reports on children's vision of the Madonna
- Encounters Steiner playing Bach in church
- Sees angelic waitress Paola by the sea
- Spots Paola beckoning to him from riverbank, but can't hear her

- Meets Maddalena at club; sleeps with her
- Dances with Sylvia at Baths of Caracalla
- Witnesses stampede at site of fake miracle
- Attends Steiner's literary salon
- Sets up father with girl
- Sleeps with Jane at aristocratic house party
- Argues with Emma
- Instigates beach orgy

- Finds fiancée Emma overdosed at apartment
- "Anointed" by Sylvia in Trevi Fountain
- Observes mourning for trampled child
- Hears Steiner has killed himself and his children
- Learns of father's stroke
- Spies matron at Mass
- Reconciles with Emma
- Discovers sea monster washed up on beach

“A man who agrees to live like this is a **finished man**, he's **nothing but a worm!**”

Marcello / La Dolce Vita

like me. Salvation doesn't lie within four walls.” That there is no comfort in either a sheltered, intellectual, domestic life nor the hedonistic “sweet life” is the existential conundrum Marcello wrestles with in the face of Steiner's subsequent suicide. After an unspecified time

lapse, we see Marcello at the beach house in Fiumicino, owned by his friend Riccardo, where the all-night party descends into mayhem. As morning approaches, he finds himself staggering across the beach, where the staring eye of the dead manta ray is waiting for him.

Minute by minute

